tion attempts, and the "2,032 offences registered at temples across the state" as examples of Jagan's regime "trampling on Hindu faith and sentiments".

Meanwhile, YSRCP leaders are calling Naidu "the real Hindu-*drohi*". Speaking to INDIA TODAY, senior leader and former legislator Malladi Vishnu said that "Jagan had rebuilt 48 temples razed in Vijayawada during Naidu's previous tenure, which shows that he is the real defender of Hindu dharma". The YSRCP has been on a counter-offensive since the SIT report, seeking an apology from Naidu for his 'animal fat' claims, and saying he and the TDP were communalising the issue for political gain.

In fact, a day after Naidu's diatribe, Jagan was seen sitting through a Vedic ritual held as part of an idol consecration and *kumbhabhishekam* ceremony at Sri Nandeeswara temple in his native Kadapa district. For good measure, Karunakar Reddy, who is also an ex-TTD chairman and a former Tirupati MLA, organised an elaborate ritual *homam* at Tirupati, seeking Jagan's "exoneration from the false accusations".

OLD ISSUE, NEW DRAMA

The YSRCP has also found fault with Naidu's one-man committee—headed by retired chief secretary Dinesh Kumar—appointed to examine the SIT report, describing it as CM Naidu's "new drama". "The CBI-SIT investigation, conducted across eight states for nearly a year, effectively gave us a clean chit...Chandrababu is now attempting to open another front to target us," says Karunakar.

Political analysts seem to share this opinion. Navyandhra Intellectual Forum chairman D.A.R. Subramanyam says the TDP is hoping to rally the Hindu votes behind it by stoking the controversy. "The TDP wants to keep the issue alive till the election in 2029, but it might have overplayed its hand in a state with no history of swaying to communal and religious narratives," he says.

Ally BJP seems to be watching the political drama from the sidelines. A senior party leader says, "Naidu appears a touch desperate, searching for any reason to damage Jagan." The BJP, incidentally, had sailed through several difficult situations in Parliament and the Rajya Sabha (like the passage of some crucial bills) during the last term with YSRCP support and has not forgotten it. "Who knows what the political situation in AP will be in three years from now?" the BJP leader asks.



THE YSRCP HAS BEEN ON A COUNTER-OFFENSIVE SINCE THE S.I.T. REPORT, SAYING CM NAIDU MUST APOLOGISE TO JAGAN FOR HIS 'ANIMAL FAT' CLAIMS

The YSRCP also has some ammunition of its own, and is demanding the sacking of current TTD chairman B.R. Naidu after some video clips, allegedly capturing him in a compromising position with a woman, surfaced on social media. B.R. Naidu, chairman of a popular Telugu news channel, TV5, has rubbished the "deep-fake video".

Meanwhile, even as accusations fly thick and fast, the TTD has been trying to clean up its act. Testing standards have been made more stringent, with the installation of quality testing equipment worth Rs 75 lakh, including a gas chromatograph (GC) and high performance liquid chromatograph (HPLC). Test parameters have also gone up, from eight to 24. The TTD is also getting itself a Rs 23.5 crore state-of-the-art food testing lab at Tirumala and is now playing it safe, procuring ghee at around Rs 650 per kg from nationally known suppliers such as Mother Dairy. TTD officials say that their feedback from pilgrims shows satisfaction with the laddu's taste and quality now. The political slugfest aside, the temple and the devotees can rest easy, for the moment at least, that their Tirumala prasadam laddu is the genuine article. ■

HOW TTD CLEANED UP ITS ACT



- **Following the controversy, TTD adopted FSSAI standards of testing, installed Rs 75 lakh quality testing equipment. Test parameters raised from 8 to 24**
- **TTD is now procuring ghee at around Rs 650 per kg from known suppliers like Mother Dairy**
- **It is also getting itself a Rs 23.5 cr. state-of-the-art food testing lab at Tirumala. FSSAI to help run lab, which opens in April**
- **Devotees haven't lost faith, around 450,000 laddus sold daily. In 2025-26, TTD earned Rs 640 cr. from laddu sales, up from Rs 550 crore in 2024-25**